In Praise of the Great Scholar Drakpa Gyaltsen

Mahāpaṇḍitakīrtijastotra · Toh 1171 · Derge Tengyur
མཁས་པ་ཆེན་པ་གྲགས་པ་རྒྱལ་མཚན་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

In Praise of the Great Scholar Drakpa Gyaltsen, whose Sanskrit title is given as Mahāpaṇḍitakīrtijastotra and whose Tibetan title is Khepa Chenpo Drakpa Gyaltsen la Töpa, is a short devotional poem honoring Drakpa Gyaltsen, who lived from 1147 to 1216 and was one of the great founding masters of the Sakya tradition of Tibet. It was composed by the Indian preceptor Sugataśrī, who translated it into Tibetan together with the Śākya monk Kunga Gyaltsen Palzangpo, better known as Sakya Paṇḍita, the master's nephew and chief disciple. In ornate verse, the poem extols Drakpa Gyaltsen as a teacher without rival in the Land of Snows, praising his learning, teaching and writing, his meditation and mastery of the Secret Mantra, his pure conduct and compassion, and his generosity in building temples and commissioning images and scriptures, before closing with a dedication of merit so that all beings may be devoted to the guru. It is Toh 1171 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra), and it is notable as a hymn by an Indian scholar addressed to a Tibetan master.

In the language of India: mahāpaṇḍitakīrtijastotraṃ
In the language of Tibet: In Praise of the Great Scholar Drakpa Gyaltsen.

Homage to Mañjughoṣa.

With garlands of songs of praise, whose flowers of words, born in the ocean of intellect, are embellished with the stamens of sweet phrases,
Finely interwoven and well strung into stainless strands, adorning their throats,
A thousand brilliant minds have praised your nature. And yet, dull as I am,
By the power of faith I praise you a little, as far as I am able; I beg the learned for their forbearance.

Embodied beings deluded by the workings of karma, a chain of illusions,
Their ship of merit wrecked in the ocean of existence, the body of their intellect sunk, abandoned by holy spiritual friends,
Through the tossing of the waves churned up by the fierce wind
Of the scriptural tradition of the eighteen limbs of awakening, have reached the far shore of the sublime state.

Since stainless adepts, the Saṅgha of monks, ascetic knowledge-holders (vidyādharas),
And hosts of lords of logic, accomplished in discipline and clear of intellect,
Touch in every way the unsullied dust of your feet,
I hold that here in this Land of Snows you have plainly become one without rival.

O holy one, your eloquent teaching is a cloud of merit
With streams of rain that make the harvest of virtue grow;
Roaring out its deep and melodious thunder,
It rouses the fortunate whose minds have fallen asleep.

Your practice of the Dharma and your teaching of many treatises,
Your composing of eloquent works and your vast recitations,
Your stainless samādhi and your way of worshiping the cakra,
Your perfectly pure view and your pure path of conduct,
And your close reliance on the ways of the ocean of Secret Mantra:
Since in all these activities of yours
No other opponent can in any way overcome you,
Such has never before been seen in any other holder of the Secret Mantra.

Great and glorious temples of many kinds, precious by nature, immeasurable mansions for the Jewels,
And sublime festivals renowned throughout the three worlds: free of attachment, you have been supremely virtuous with your glory and wealth,
And your deeds are vast in every way: images of the Sage (the Buddha) and pure scriptures fashioned from precious substances.
There is none equal to you, and so the river of my mind's delight swells like a lake in summer.

As your stainless merit outshines the moonbeams and the rays of your loving-kindness stream forth,
The blemished moon in the sky cannot bear your splendor,
And surely longs to enter the depths of the ocean in the form of a reflection.
As my mind thinks this, supreme wonder has arisen in me.

Of stainless lineage and vast qualities,
You are attended by scholars of peerless intellect;
Intent on benefiting others, a haven for the destitute,
You are vast in your deeds and utterly at peace.
There is none equal to you, and so you, beyond any simile,

Cannot be praised in every respect.
Nevertheless, eager to praise you a little,
And granted permission by the learned monk Jangchub Özer,
I have clearly set this down
Just as it appeared to me.

I, the scholar Sugataśrī, have praised well
The supremely marvelous Drakpa Gyaltsen;
Whatever merit there is in this,
By it may all beings be devoted to the guru.

This completes the Praise of the Great Being Drakpa Gyaltsen, composed by the Indian preceptor Sugataśrī. It was translated by that same Indian preceptor and the Śākya monk Kunga Gyaltsen Palzangpo.

Translator's Notes

• The phrase rendered "the eighteen limbs of awakening" reads literally "three sets of six limbs of awakening"; which eighteen are meant is unclear, since the limbs of awakening are usually counted as seven. In the second verse, "spiritual friends" follows the evident reading bshes gnyen for the text's shes gnyen. The learned monk Jangchub Özer, who gave the author permission to compose the praise, is not otherwise identified; his name is taken to be Tibetan and given in phonetics.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.